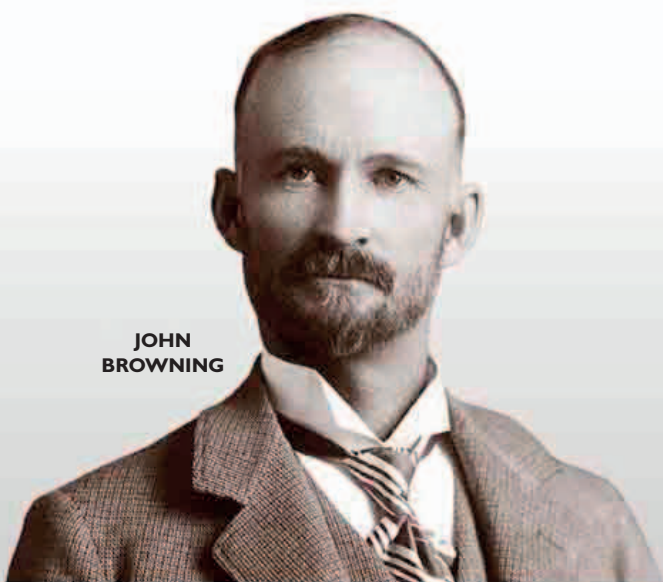




JOHN BROWNING

GREAT GUNSMITHS

BROWNING

John Moses Browning was one of the most versatile and widely respected gunmakers in history. Although he began as a gunsmith, based in a small workshop in his native Utah, he built his reputation not as a manufacturer but as a designer of firearms. He sold his designs to gunmakers such as Winchester, Colt, and the Belgian firm Fabrique Nationale. He became famous for the build quality and practicality of his firearms, and for his innovations, especially in the field of automatic weapons.

From the age of seven, John Browning worked for his father, Jonathan, a gunsmith in Ogden, Utah. This is where he learned the basics of the gunsmith's craft and was soon experimenting and coming up with ideas of his own. Within a few years, he had built his first gun, a single-shot rifle for his brother, Matt, and by 1879, when John was 24, he and his brother set up their own workshop. The Brownings quickly established a reputation for efficient, well-made weapons. Their small workshop could not keep up with the demand, but the brothers did not have the capital to expand. So in 1883, Browning started to sell manufacturing rights to Winchester, beginning a fruitful business relationship that produced some of the best-known firearms made in the US.

THE BROWNING APPROACH

The 1880s and 1890s were fruitful decades for John Browning. During this time he produced many weapons in partnership with the Winchester Repeating Arms Company. His approach was to design guns that were simple in layout and therefore straightforward to manufacture and repair, as well as being robust enough to be reliable under the sometimes punishing conditions of the American West.

**◀ TESTING A PROTOTYPE**

John Browning tests a prototype of his heavy machine-gun in around 1918. This firearm, a water-cooled .50in caliber weapon, was an enlarged version of the .30in caliber M1917 gun.

The first design Winchester bought from Browning was the single-shot rifle he was producing in his workshop in Ogden. This impressed Thomas G. Bennett, president and general manager of Winchester, when he visited Ogden in 1883. It became the Winchester Model 1885. The gun sold well, especially to users who wanted a rifle for long-range target shooting, and gained an excellent reputation. Its falling block action was so strong that Winchester used it for the punishing job of testing new cartridges. It cemented Browning's reputation as a creator of rugged, effective firearms.

Once he had sold the Model 1885 to Winchester, the young gunsmith was free to concentrate on designing new firearms for the company, and the Model 1886, a

high-powered repeating rifle, soon appeared. This was followed by the Model 1892, a lighter gun popular with cowboys, the Model 1895, a bigger weapon designed for hunters, and the Model 1897 (see p.183), the first effective repeating shotgun, a weapon used by Wells Fargo bank guards and the US military. A total contrast was the Model 90, a lightweight weapon that was often given to young people who were learning to shoot. Altogether, Browning sold more than 40 designs to Winchester, 10 of which made it into production, along with designing weapons for other companies. It was an outstanding achievement that made Browning one of the most celebrated firearms designers in the world.

NEW BREAKTHROUGHS

Some of Browning's most notable breakthroughs came in the field of automatic weapons. In the late 1880s, he developed the first effective gas-operated automatic gun. Gas-operated firearms (see pp.194–95) use the high-pressure gas generated when a cartridge is fired to power a mechanism that extracts the spent cartridge case and delivers another one to the chamber. He offered his design to Colt and it eventually became the Colt M1895 machine-gun (see p.194), which could fire more than 400 rounds per

“If anything can happen in a **gun**, it probably will sooner or later.”
